A WILLOW LANE MYSTERY

Mila and the Missing Moon



A mystery to share, one chapter at a time

CHAPTER 1

The Empty Table

Mila had brought a whole pocketful of stars to the library, but the moon was missing.

At first, she thought she had the wrong table.

She checked the one beside the window. Scissors, string, a cup of cold tea. She checked the one beside the shelves. Three paper fish with very surprised faces.

“Dad,” she said. “Where's our moon?”

Dad set down his bag of battery lights. “Mrs. Bell?”

The librarian came out from behind a tower of books. A pencil stuck out of her hair.

“You're just who I need. Did you move the moon after lunch?”

Mila shook her head. Yesterday, she and Noah had helped cover a round frame with white tissue paper. The moon was so wide that Mila couldn't reach around it. Tonight, it would lead the lantern walk down Willow Lane.

She had practiced walking very slowly beside it.

“I left it right here,” she said.

Mrs. Bell looked at the empty table.

“So did I.”



Mila emptied her pocket. The paper stars fluttered onto the table. She had cut them out before lunch to hang beneath the moon.

They looked rather silly without it.

“It can't have gone far,” Dad said. “When did you last see it?”

“This morning,” said Mrs. Bell. “I put it in a box so the little lantern makers wouldn't poke holes in the paper. A big, flat box. It was still on this table when I went to eat my lunch.”

“With the moon inside?” Mila asked.

“Yes. I shut the lid myself.”

Mila looked under the table. There was a crayon, a bent star, and one of her own shoes. The shoe was still on her foot.

No box.

Dad checked behind the folding screen. Mrs. Bell checked the cupboard where they kept the cushions. Mila opened the door to the tiny kitchen.

“If it's in there,” Dad said, “ask it to make some tea.”

Mila almost smiled.



Noah arrived carrying a ruler and a small notebook.

“I worked out how long the star strings should be,” he said. Then he saw their faces. “What happened?”

“The moon's gone. And its box.”

He put the ruler down.

Mila ran her hand along the table edge. Something soft caught against her finger. A tiny yellow thread stuck out of a rough place in the wood.

“Wait.”

Mrs. Bell leaned closer. “Oh. I tied the box with yellow wool. We had a ball left from the pom-pom day.”

Mila bent until her nose was almost level with the thread. It was fuzzy, with a little curl at the end.

“Could the box have caught here?” she asked.

“It could,” said Mrs. Bell. “The knot hung over that edge.”

Mila wanted to pull the thread free. Instead, she left it where it was.

Noah opened his notebook. The first page held careful sums about stars.

“There's room on the next page,” he said.



Mila wrote slowly with Noah's pencil.

Moon in box. Both gone.

Under that, she wrote, *Yellow wool on table.*

“Shall I put who took it?” Noah asked.

“We don't know who.”

“I meant leave a space.”

“Oh. Yes.”

She left a very large space.

Outside, someone shook out a string of little bells. They jingled all at once. People were already getting ready for tonight.

“Can we look in the yard?” Mila asked Dad.

“Together,” he said. “I'll help Mrs. Bell check the other rooms first. Then we'll go out.”

Mrs. Bell picked up one of Mila's paper stars. Its points were uneven. Mila had liked it best until now.

“We'll hang these somewhere,” the librarian said gently. “Even if we have to lead the walk with a fish.”

Mila glanced at the paper fish. A fish would be funny.

But she wanted their moon.

She tucked the stars into Dad's bag, and helped him open the next door.

CHAPTER 2

Something White

The moon was not in the reading room. It was not in the storeroom, either, though Mila found enough spare paper to make a second moon.

There wasn't time for that. The first one had taken two whole afternoons.

Dad carried his bag of lights and stars to the back door. Noah tucked his ruler into his pocket and held out the notebook.

“You keep it for now,” he told Mila.

She held it open as they stepped into the yard.

The library's back step was dark gray. Across it ran several pale lines.

Mila stopped so suddenly that Dad nearly bumped into her.

“Look.”

One line curved around the corner of the step. Another ran beside it. On the paving stones below, the lines spread farther apart.

“Wheels?” Noah said.

Mila followed them with her eyes. Something with wheels had come through this door. Something that could carry a very big box.



“Nobody step on them,” Mila said.

Dad lifted one foot and put it down somewhere else.

Noah crouched beside the step. Mila crouched too. The white stuff was dry at the edges, thicker in the middle. In one line, a little piece was missing. Farther along, there was another gap.

“Like a dotted line,” Noah said.

“A mostly undotted line.”

He grinned. Then he took his ruler from his pocket and laid it beside a gap.

Mila looked across the yard. At the far end, a path split around a low bed of mint. The left branch went through a wooden gate toward the community garden. The right branch went past the bakery's back wall.

Someone had put folding tables near the mint. Bright paper scraps trembled in a breeze.

Noah took back his notebook and began drawing the doorway, the tables, and the path.

“We need clues,” Mila said. “Not a picture.”

He kept drawing.



The bakery door opened.

Bea backed out with a tall stack of metal trays. White dust covered the front of her apron. There was a pale handprint on one pocket.

Mila looked from the apron to the lines on the ground.

“Flour,” she whispered.

“Maybe,” said Noah.

Bea turned, saw them, and smiled. “How's our moon coming along?”

Mila didn't answer at once.

“We've lost it,” Dad said. “We're checking the yard.”

“Oh, no.” Bea shifted the trays against her hip. “I brought the biscuit trays into the library after lunch. The table by the window was clear, so I left them there.”

“The moon table?” Mila asked.

“If that's where it was, yes.”

Bea had been in the library. Bea had wheels for moving heavy things. Bea was covered in white powder.

Mila felt a small, hot fizz inside her chest.

Perhaps this was what finding the answer felt like.



“We should look at her cart,” Mila whispered to Noah.

“And compare the white stuff,” he whispered back.

“It's flour. She works in a bakery.”

“But we haven't touched it yet.”

Dad was lifting the trays from Bea's arms. She rubbed her shoulder and thanked him.

Mila remembered Bea laughing yesterday when the moon frame rolled against a chair. She had called it a great clumsy pancake.

Perhaps she had wanted the table for her biscuits. Perhaps she had put the box outside and someone else had taken it. That would explain everything.

Well, most things.

Mila needed to ask before she lost the thought.

She shut the notebook over Noah's unfinished drawing and held it against her chest.

“Come on,” she said.

Noah stood up. “I still want to measure—”

But Mila was already crossing the yard. Bea stood by the bakery door, wiping her dusty hands down her apron.

Mila had her question ready.

CHAPTER 3

The Wrong Question

“Why did you take our moon?” Mila asked.

Bea's hands stopped moving.

“I didn't.”

“But you wanted the table. And there's flour all the way out of the library.”

Bea looked toward the step. Her smile had gone.

“I used an empty table, Mila. If something was in my way, I would ask someone to help move it.”

The hot fizz in Mila's chest began to feel different.

Dad came back from the bakery with empty hands.

“What's happening?”

“Mila thinks I took the lantern.” Bea spoke quietly. That was somehow worse than shouting.

“We found white wheel marks,” Mila said.

“You did,” Dad said. “What else do you know?”

She wanted to say that she knew plenty. But all she could see was Bea's hand, still gripping the edge of her apron.

Noah touched Mila's sleeve.

“Can we try the white stuff now?”

Bea gave them a pinch of flour in a saucer. Dad brought two more saucers and a mug of water from the library.

With an old spoon, Noah scraped up a little dry powder from the edge of a wheel mark. Mila fetched a crumb of pale dirt from the muddy patch beside the garden gate.

Three samples. Three saucers.

They added a little water to each and stirred with separate sticks.

Bea's flour became a sticky white lump. The dirt made a gritty, cream-colored smear. So did the powder from the track.

Mila rubbed a bit between her fingers. Tiny grains scratched her skin.

“These two feel alike,” she said.

Dad peered at them. “This patch has pale clay in it. Wheels have been going through it all day.”

Mila looked at the flour again. Their trail sample didn't look or feel like Bea's sample at all.

She wished she had done this first.

Bea's tray cart stood just inside her door. It had two large wheels and a handle, like a shopping trolley.

Noah checked both wheels. Their rubber edges were smooth. With his ruler, he measured how far apart they were.

Back at the library step, he measured the space between the two long, straight tracks. They were much closer together than Bea's wheels. At the turn, the lines spread into several curved marks. The little gaps kept appearing in one outside line.

Mila drew Bea's two wheels on the page beneath her notes. Then she drew the narrower pair of tracks.

They weren't the same.

Through the bakery door came the smell of warm biscuits. Mila usually liked that smell very much. Now it made her feel smaller.

“I'll wait here,” Noah said.

She shook her head. “You can come.”

Dad stayed beside the step as they crossed the yard.

Bea was putting a cloth over a bowl.

“I was wrong,” Mila said. “I said you took it before I knew. I'm sorry.”

She kept her eyes on Bea this time.

Bea set the bowl down.

“Thank you for coming back to tell me.”

Mila waited. Bea didn't say that it didn't matter. Mila was glad, a little. It had mattered.

“Could I ask a different question?”

“You can.”

“Did you see a big, flat box when you brought the trays?”

Bea rubbed her chin with the back of her wrist.

“Not inside. But I passed a trolley in the yard. There was a square box on it, tied with yellow wool.”

Mila's fingers tightened around the pencil.

“Who was pushing?” Noah asked.

“I couldn't see. I was carrying my trays in front of me. Whoever it was waited while I squeezed past.”

“What kind of trolley?”

“Low and wooden. Four small wheels, I think. I was mostly watching my biscuits.”

Mila wrote it down, leaving space beneath it.

This time, she hadn't found an answer.

But she had a much better question.

CHAPTER 4

A Wheel with a Bite

“Low and wooden,” Mila told Mrs. Bell. “With four small wheels.”

The librarian pointed behind the open back door.

There, in a narrow space beside a broom, stood a low wooden trolley.

Mila stared at it. She had walked right past.

“We use it for book boxes,” Mrs. Bell said. “Mr. Moss borrowed it today. He was taking things to the garden.”

“Can we look underneath?” Noah asked.

Dad tipped the empty trolley onto its side and held it steady. Three wheels had smooth rubber edges. The fourth had a piece missing.

It looked as if a very small creature had taken one bite.

Noah brought out his ruler again. The back wheels were the right distance apart for the long tracks.

Mila crouched beside the damaged wheel.

“That would leave a gap.”

“Let's see,” said Noah.

Dad lowered the trolley. Mila moved her toes out of the way.



They wheeled the trolley to the pale muddy patch by the garden gate. Dad helped them roll just the back wheels through it, then onto a clean paving stone.

Two pale lines appeared. One had a little break.

The wheel turned again.

Another break.

Noah measured the space between the breaks, using his ruler twice. Then they went back to the old marks near the library door.

The spaces matched. So did the width of the wheel marks.

“I think this is the trolley,” Mila said.

She wrote that beneath Bea's words. This time, she added why.

Dad took a picture of the old tracks with his phone before anyone could step on them.

Noah drew the wheel with its missing bite in the notebook. Mila waited for him to finish.

“Does Mr. Moss have the moon?” she asked Dad.

“We can ask.”

He tapped a message into his phone while Noah wiped the ruler on a leaf.



The answer came while Dad was returning the trolley to its place.

“He says he moved garden boxes and brought the trolley back,” Dad told them. “He didn't see a moon lantern. He's collecting plants for the garden now and will be back soon.”

“But it was in a box,” Mila said.

“I've told him that. He'll help us look when he gets here.”

Noah stood on the library step, looking down at the marks.

“Where did the trolley go?”

They could follow two pale lines across the first few stones. Near the folding tables, wheels had swung in a wide curve.

Mila walked beside the marks, keeping her shoes off them.

“Into the yard,” she said. “Not through the front door to the road.”

“At least this journey went into the yard,” Noah said.

She nodded. The trolley might have made other journeys. They had watched it make one themselves.

Still, this was somewhere to start.



A table leg stood across the next mark.

Dad moved the table a little, and Mila found the line again. It ran past a crushed blue paper flower and faded on a rough stone.

Beyond it, shoes and wheels had crossed the yard in every direction.

Mila could see neither a neat trail to the bakery nor one to the garden gate.

Noah opened the notebook to his drawing of the yard. “I think that table was—”

A drop of water struck the page.

Then another landed on Mila's nose.

Across the yard, the paper flowers began to shake. A woman gathering paint cups called for someone to bring the drying pictures inside.

Dad picked up his bag. “Under the roof, you two.”

Mila turned back once. Rain dotted the pale wheel marks. The little gaps in the line were getting harder to see.

She covered Noah's notebook with both hands and ran for the library door.

CHAPTER 5

Rain on the Notebook

They reached the narrow roof above the library steps just as the rain became a proper shower.

Dad shook drops from his hair. One went down Mila's neck.

“Sorry,” he said.

Mila held the notebook open. A wet spot had blurred the corner of Noah's drawing. She pressed it carefully against the dry part of her sleeve.

Out in the yard, the pale tracks were turning to watery streaks.

“They're washing away.”

Dad showed her the photograph on his phone. She could see the marks by the doorway, including the little gaps.

But the picture didn't show the whole yard.

Aunt June came hurrying along the garden path. Her coat hung over a basket of paper lanterns instead of over her shoulders.

“Hold this,” she told Dad, giving him the basket.

Then she stood beneath the roof and dripped.

Mila hugged her around the damp middle anyway.

“We've lost the moon,” she said into her aunt's shirt.



Aunt June looked at the empty space where Mila's arms reached around her.

“That's quite a lot of moon to lose.”

Mila explained about the box and the wool, the wheel marks and the trolley.

“Mr. Moss brought some garden boxes over earlier,” Aunt June said. “Then people put more supplies out for the lantern makers. We've just carried everything into the shed to keep it dry.”

Mila lifted her head.

“Did you see our box?”

“I saw several big boxes. I didn't open them. We were trying to beat the rain.”

“Could we look?”

“Of course. Give the shower a few minutes. I need to find the shed key in this enormous pocket.”

She pulled out string, a folded paper bag, and a tiny plastic dinosaur.

“Not that.”

“Why have you got a dinosaur?” Noah asked.

“Excellent question.” She put it on the windowsill. “Perhaps it can guard the basket.”

Mila watched water fall from the roof in silver strings.



When the rain thinned, they walked toward the gate. The air smelled of wet leaves and the mint beside the path.

A small yellow curl hung from the gate latch.

Mila caught Dad's arm.

“More wool!”

It was longer than the thread on the table, with one frayed end. She leaned close, careful of the wet latch.

“The box came this way.”

Aunt June reached into her basket and lifted a bundle of bamboo sticks. Yellow wool held them together.

“Possibly,” she said. “But we've tied lots of things with this wool today. The garden has a whole bag of it.”

Noah turned the bundle until Mila could see its knot.

The wool looked exactly like the scrap on the gate.

Mila let go of Dad's sleeve. A moment ago, the yellow curl had seemed to point straight to the moon.

Now it was only a curl on a gate.

She left it where it hung.



They waited beneath the spreading tree beside the path while Aunt June went to collect a second basket.

Mila watched a drop crawl along the edge of a leaf. At the tip, it grew fat, trembled, and fell onto her shoe.

“We could look in the bakery lane first,” she said.

“Why?” Noah asked.

“It's nearer.”

“The shed's not far.”

“But what if it never went to the shed?”

She was tired of finding things that almost meant something. A white line. A yellow thread. A trolley with no moon on it.

Noah opened the notebook across his palm.

“Can I show you my picture now?”

“It's wet.”

“Only one corner.”

Dad leaned against the tree and waited. He didn't choose a path for them.

Mila looked down at the page she had shut before Noah was finished.

The library door was there. So were the tables.

And so was something she had forgotten.

CHAPTER 6

The Map That Wasn't

Noah had drawn a large rectangle beside the mint bed. Inside it was a wobbly circle.

“What's that?” Mila asked.

“The lantern table. With the paint bowl.”

She looked up. There was no table there now.

“They carried it inside when it rained,” Noah said. “You can see where its legs were.”

On the paving stones were four small dry squares, slowly darkening.

Mila remembered the bowl. Someone had been washing a brush in it when she and Noah first came out.

Noah put his finger on two lines in his drawing. They curved past the library door, then bent toward the left.

“I drew the tracks I could see.”

“You drew those?”

“That's why I wanted the ruler.”

Mila looked harder. She had thought he was drawing tables because he liked drawing tables. She hadn't asked.

The little lines went around the place where the lantern table had stood.



Mila carried the notebook back across the yard. Dad and Noah came beside her.

Under the library's overhanging roof, a pale bit of track had survived. Farther out, everything was dark and wet.

She turned the notebook so its doorway faced the real doorway.

“Here?” she asked.

Noah nodded.

She followed the drawn lines with one finger. They headed toward the gate. The other path, past the bakery, lay beyond the table's old position.

“If the trolley went right, wouldn't it have hit the table?”

“Or it could have turned again,” Noah said.

Mila pictured someone steering a big box between table legs and chairs. She couldn't quite make the turn fit in her head.

“Can you show me?”

Noah looked up.

“With the trolley,” she said. “You work out where the table was. I'll help.”

“We'll need something to mark the legs.”

Dad offered four fallen twigs.

Mila took them from him.



They put one twig beside each dry square.

Dad brought out the empty trolley. Noah lined its back wheels up with the marks beneath the roof. Then he pushed slowly along the curve in his drawing.

Mila walked beside the corner, holding the notebook where he could see it.

The trolley rolled past the twig table and pointed toward the garden gate.

“Now try going to the bakery,” she said.

They returned to the beginning. Noah tried turning right where the drawn tracks turned left. The trolley's corner swept over one of the twigs.

“Table leg,” Mila said.

He tried a wider turn. This time the trolley missed the twig, but its wheels left the route he'd drawn.

“It could get there,” Noah said. “Just not along those marks.”

Mila looked down the garden path. “Let's try the shed first.”

She picked up the twigs while Noah backed the trolley away.

There was room for his drawing in the notebook after all.



Dad put the trolley back. Mila waited for Noah at the gate.

“I shouldn't have called it just a picture,” she said.

“It is a picture.”

“You know what I mean.”

He did. She could tell by the way he took the notebook without shutting it.

“You draw better maps than me,” she said.

“You ask more questions.”

“Some bad ones.”

Noah bent to move a snail out of the path. He set it beneath the mint, facing away from everyone's shoes.

“Ask June if she's got the key yet.”

Mila laughed. That was a question she could manage.

Aunt June came back with the basket on one arm and a key held high in the other hand.

They went through the gate together. The garden smelled of damp soil. Beyond the beds, a small shed stood under a plum tree.

Its roof was still ticking with drops.

Mila hurried to keep up with Noah.

CHAPTER 7

Boxes, Boxes

The shed door stuck. Aunt June pushed it with her shoulder, and it opened with a wooden groan.

Inside, everything smelled of wood, earth, and the sharp green smell of tomato leaves.

Dad hooked the door open. Daylight fell across a row of watering cans and a very large number of boxes.

There were boxes on shelves. Boxes on the floor. Boxes leaning against other boxes as if they were tired.

Mila had expected to see one box with yellow wool around it.

She could see at least six.

Some were deep. Several were broad and flat, like the one Mrs. Bell had described.

“Oh,” Noah said.

Aunt June set down her basket. “We'll start with the ones we can reach.”

Mila stepped around a watering can. On a low shelf, a wide cardboard box had one word written in thick black letters.

STARS.

She looked at Dad's bag.

Her stars were still inside it.



“Could someone else have made stars?” Mila asked.

“Certainly,” said Aunt June.

She lifted the box down, untied its yellow wool, and opened the lid.

Inside were small empty plant pots, stacked in rows.

Noah picked up one of the pots and looked through the hole in its bottom.

“Very small stars.”

Mila laughed despite herself.

“We use boxes again,” Aunt June said. “That one held paper stars for the winter fair. I should have crossed the old word out.”

Mila put a hand against the cardboard. The word was clear and dark. It looked like a promise about what was inside.

But it wasn't.

June set the open box near the door. Dad checked behind it.

Only more pots.

At the back of the shed, three wide cartons were stacked beneath a heavy wooden tray. Another flat box stood against the wall beside them.

Mila could see yellow ties. She couldn't see all the writing.



“We'll need to move the tray first,” Dad said.

Mila reached toward the nearest corner.

“That's a two-grown-up lift,” Aunt June said. “You can keep the doorway clear for us.”

Mila moved the watering cans outside, one at a time. Noah carried the smaller ones. They lined them up beneath the plum tree.

Footsteps crunched on the path.

Mr. Moss came around the corner pulling a handcart full of green plants. A leaf had stuck to his sleeve.

“Any luck with your lantern?” he asked.

“Not yet,” Mila said. “Did you carry a big, flat box from the library?”

“Yes. Along with two smaller ones. They were waiting by the back door.”

“On the table?”

“The big one was. I slid it onto the trolley.”

Mila pictured the yellow knot catching on the rough wood.

“What was in it?”

Mr. Moss shook his head. “I didn't look inside.”



“I was taking garden supplies over,” Mr. Moss said. “The big box said TO THE GARDEN. So that's where I took it.”

“Our moon was in a big box,” Mila said.

His eyebrows rose. “Then I may owe your moon a ride home.”

“Where did you put it?” Noah asked.

“Against that wall, with the others. Before the rain.”

He pointed toward the boxes behind the wooden tray.

Aunt June looked at the stack. “We had to put a lot more in front when the shower started.”

Mr. Moss took off his coat. “Let's make some room and start opening them.”

Mila stood back as he and June lifted the heavy tray. Dad caught a loose flowerpot before it rolled.

There were more boxes behind it than Mila had seen.

Somewhere among them might be a moon.

She opened Noah's notebook and looked at the space she had left for a name.

Then she turned to a clean page.

CHAPTER 8

Start Again

Mila wrote *TO THE GARDEN* across the clean page.

“If it said that, why did Mrs. Bell use it?” she asked.

Noah sat beside her on the low wall outside the shed. “Maybe it wasn't the same box.”

Inside, June and Mr. Moss had opened a carton of folded paper. They were making space to reach the next one.

Dad put his bag down beside Mila. The tip of a paper star poked out.

“We should take these back,” she said. “They're getting bent.”

She smoothed the point with her thumb.

“And ask Mrs. Bell about the box?” Noah said.

Mila nodded. She wanted to begin at the empty table again. Now she had a different question to bring to it.

Dad told Aunt June where they were going.

“We'll keep checking here,” her aunt said. “We can lay the flat boxes out once we've cleared this side.”

Mila lifted the bag herself.

Back at the library, the paper fish had gained shiny tails.

Mrs. Bell was helping a little boy stick scales onto one with the back of a spoon.

“We've found lots of boxes,” Mila told her. “Mr. Moss moved one that said TO THE GARDEN.”

“He may have moved mine, then,” said Mrs. Bell. “I borrowed the box from June yesterday. It was empty.”

“Did you write anything on it?” Noah asked.

“MOON.”

Mila set Dad's bag on a chair.

“On the lid?”

“No. The lid had an old picture on it. I wrote on a thin side, where there was space.”

She held her hands apart to show the shallow edge.

Mila thought of the STARS box and its rows of pots. One old word could stay on a box while something quite different went inside.

“Did you check the other sides?” she asked.

Mrs. Bell put down the spoon.

“I'm afraid I didn't.”

Noah drew a box. On one edge, he wrote MOON. On the opposite edge, he wrote TO THE GARDEN.

Mila stood a book on the table to be the shed wall. Noah held his drawing beside it.

“If this side faced the wall—” he began.

“We couldn't read it,” Mila said.

“But Mr. Moss could read this one.”

She turned the notebook around. It was such a small turn.

Mrs. Bell brought over a clean sheet of cardboard. Mila and Noah spread the paper stars on it so they wouldn't curl in Dad's bag.

“The moon filled most of the box,” the librarian said. “There was hardly room for my fingers beside the frame.”

Mila remembered their wide round frame on the worktable. It had been thin, almost like a huge coin.

A deep, narrow carton wouldn't hold it. A broad, shallow one would.

She circled Noah's drawing with the pencil.



“We need to look at the flat ones,” Mila said. “And read every side.”

“They're opening boxes already,” Dad reminded her.

“I know. But they might not need to open them all.”

Mrs. Bell helped Dad slide the stars into a drawer to keep them safe.

“Tell me as soon as you find it,” she said. “If it's there.”

Mila liked that last bit less than she wanted to. It left a little space for being wrong.

She left it in her head, too.

Outside, the shower had stopped. The mint leaves shone. Someone was carrying the lantern table back into the yard.

Noah walked beside her, turning the notebook so the damp corner could dry in the air.

“Your page is flapping,” Mila said.

“It's trying to fly.”

She caught the edge before the wind could tear it.

Then they walked with the notebook held between them, all the way to the shed.

CHAPTER 9

The Other Side

Two flat boxes lay open outside the shed. One held folded bunting. The other was full of empty seed trays.

Neither held the moon.

“Mrs. Bell wrote MOON on an edge,” Mila told Aunt June. “There could be two messages on the same box.”

Noah showed her the drawing.

“Then let's turn the next ones so you can read them,” June said.

She and Mr. Moss brought out a broad carton. Its front edge said PAPER. Its back edge said BLUE POTS.

Inside were paintbrushes.

“That box needs a new name,” Noah said.

“Several fewer names,” Mr. Moss agreed.

Mila waited beside the wall as Dad helped June lift another carton down. It was shallow and square, with yellow wool crossing its middle.

On the edge facing Mila were three words.

TO THE GARDEN.

She didn't reach for the knot.

“Can you turn it?” she asked.



Dad and June turned the box slowly between them.

On the opposite edge, four black letters came into view.

Mila read them before the box had stopped moving.

“MOON.”

Noah let out one long breath. Mila hadn't known he was holding it.

They laid the carton flat on the cleared bench. June loosened the wool. The knot had pulled tight, so Mr. Moss fetched a small pair of scissors and snipped it.

Dad lifted the lid.

White tissue paper curved around the round frame. Mila knew the place where two sheets met in a slightly crooked line. She had pasted that part herself.

“There you are,” she said.

She hadn't meant to speak to it as if it were a lost cat.

Noah touched the wooden frame with one finger. Then he grinned at her across the box.

Mila grinned back so hard that her cheeks hurt.

The moon had been in the garden all this time.



Mr. Moss looked from one label to the other.

“I never turned it around,” he said. “I saw where it was meant to go and took it there.”

He pointed to the old message. Mila looked at the new one, hidden against the shed wall until now.

“It had two different jobs,” she said.

“And I gave it the wrong one.”

“We can fix the writing,” Noah said.

Mila looked along the yellow wool. One loose end was ragged. A little part could easily have caught on the table.

The wool hadn't told her whose box it was. The wheel hadn't told her what was inside. But they had brought her here.

“Shall I take it back on the trolley?” Mr. Moss asked.

Mila started to say no. Then she looked at the wide box and the muddy path.

“If we put the lid on carefully,” she said.

Dad was still looking inside.

“There's a small tear here.”



Near the lower edge, the tissue had split in a short, crooked line. A cardboard tab inside the lid pressed against the same spot.

Mila's smile slipped.

Noah bent to look. “It's not the frame.”

“No,” Dad said. “Just the paper. We can patch it.”

June folded the tab away and taped it flat so it couldn't catch again. Mila watched her hands. She wanted to get the moon home, but she didn't want to rush it into another problem.

“I'll tell Mrs. Bell,” Dad said, taking out his phone.

Mila picked up the notebook. Under the drawing of the two-sided box, she wrote *Found*.

It was a lovely short word. She pressed so hard the pencil nearly went through the page.

Noah put his ruler under the corner before she could make a hole.

Then Mr. Moss went to fetch the trolley, and Mila stayed beside the open box, keeping the lid from blowing shut.

CHAPTER 10

A Moon with a Scar

This time, the moon arrived at the library with a small crowd walking beside it.

Mr. Moss pushed the trolley. Dad watched the box. Mila carried the notebook, and Noah carried nothing so he could open the doors.

Mrs. Bell was waiting at the worktable.

“Oh, my moon.”

“Our moon,” Mila said, then wondered if that sounded rude.

But Mrs. Bell smiled. “Quite right.”

They lifted the frame out and laid it on clean paper. Mrs. Bell examined the tear.

“The lid caught when I packed it this morning,” she said. “I thought I'd only bent the cardboard.”

She brought tissue paper and a little bowl of paste. Noah washed his hands, and Mila washed hers.

“We need a patch a bit bigger than the tear,” Mrs. Bell said. “Then we'll leave it flat until it's dry.”

Mila chose a clean white sheet. She wanted the mend to disappear.



Noah took one of Mila's paper stars from the drawer.

“What about this shape?”

He laid it beside the tear. The points spread wide enough to cover the split.

“Everyone would see it,” Mila said.

“They'll see a square patch too.”

“We could make a round one.”

Noah put the star down. “We could.”

Mila held the tissue against the light. Even one extra layer would show a little. She looked at the star again. It was the uneven one she had liked that morning.

“Let's try it.”

Noah traced around it gently. Mila cut the tissue while he held the sheet steady. The last point was tricky, so she turned the paper instead of twisting the scissors.

Mrs. Bell showed them how little paste they needed. Together they brushed it around the tear and smoothed the patch over it.

Mila lifted her hands slowly.

The star stayed where they had put it.



“Now we wait,” said Mrs. Bell.

Mila looked at the clock.

It was still afternoon. The walk wasn't until the sky grew dark. But waiting felt much longer than looking for something.

She wanted to touch the patch to see if it was dry.

Instead, she and Noah measured strings for the paper stars. His sums were still on the notebook's first page. They worked just as well as they had before the moon went missing.

At another table, Aunt June made new labels for the garden boxes. Mr. Moss crossed out the old messages with a thick pen.

“One job each,” he said, showing Mila a label that read EMPTY POTS.

She fetched the dinosaur from the windowsill and set it on top of the stack.

“What does his label say?” Noah asked.

“Guard.”

“He's not very big.”

“Neither are the pots.”

They finished the strings while the clock's hands crept around.



By the time the patch was dry, the yard was busy again. Lanterns lined the tables, waiting for their little battery lights.

Mrs. Bell checked the mend, then let Mila lift the frame with Noah.

The paper held.

Dad fixed two cloth loops to the frame and hung it from a smooth wooden bar. Mila and Noah tied their strings of stars along the bottom.

“Would you two like to help carry it?” he asked. “I'll hold the middle and take the weight.”

“Both of us?” Mila asked.

“It's a wide moon.”

Noah tried one end of the bar. Mila took the other. They practiced moving around a chair without knocking the stars against it.

They bumped the chair once.

On the next try, they slowed down together.

Behind the white paper, the star patch showed faintly. Mila could still see the crooked join she had pasted yesterday.

She checked the strings one last time.

Everything was ready.

CHAPTER 11

One Small Light

At dusk, Dad clipped a small battery light behind the moon's paper and pressed its switch.

The moon glowed.

Mila had seen the white sheets, the paste, the bare frame, and the inside of the box. She knew how it all fitted together.

Still, she leaned closer.

The little patch made a pale star near the bottom. Below it, the strings swayed, each carrying one of Mila's cut-out stars.

Noah stood on the other side of the bar, looking through the fringe.

“Can you see me?” he asked.

“Only your nose.”

He moved his head. Now she could see one eye too.

Behind them, the library yard filled with glowing fish, houses, flowers, and things Mila couldn't name. One little boy carried a paper shape with six legs and a hat.

Dad lowered the middle of the bar into his hands.

“Ready?”

Mila took her end. Noah took his.



They went slowly across the yard. Dad carried the weight while Mila and Noah kept the ends steady.

For a few steps, Mila watched only the paving stones. She didn't want to trip now.

Then she looked up.

Lantern light slid over wet leaves. The puddle by the mint held an upside-down paper fish. Every time the child carrying it moved, the fish in the puddle wriggled.

At the bakery corner, Bea waited with a basket on her arm.

Mila felt a small tightness in her stomach. She almost looked down again.

“Would you walk beside us?” she asked.

Bea glanced at the broad moon. “Is there room?”

“On my side.”

Bea joined them. Warm biscuit smells came from her basket.

“I'm glad you found it,” she said.

“Noah's map helped,” Mila told her. “And he worked out the wheel marks.”

Across the bar, Noah looked pleased. Then he pointed ahead.

“Gatepost,” he said.

They all moved a little left.



The walk wound through the garden. Aunt June had hung small lights along the fence, and the plum tree spread dark branches over their heads.

Beside the shed, Mr. Moss stood with the plastic dinosaur in his coat pocket.

“Right destination this time?” he asked.

“Just passing through,” Mila said.

At the end of the garden, everyone stopped while the people at the back caught up. Dad rested the bar on two supports someone had set beside a bench.

Mila loosened her fingers. She hadn't noticed how tightly she was holding on.

Bea passed around small round biscuits. Mila broke hers in half and gave a piece to Dad.

Crumbs fell onto his coat.

“A useful pocket,” he said, catching one.

Noah sat beside Mila, balancing his biscuit on one knee. The moon hung in front of them, bright against the shed's dark wall.

For a little while, nobody needed to carry it or fix it or find it.



They returned to the library along Willow Lane. The real moon had come out between two thin clouds.

Mila looked up at it, then at theirs.

Theirs was lower. It also had strings.

She liked it very much.

Back in the yard, the little boy with the six-legged lantern asked why the moon had a star on its face.

“It needed a patch,” Noah said.

“Mine needs a tail.”

“Ask Mrs. Bell,” Mila told him. “She's got more paper.”

Dad and Mr. Moss carried the moon inside. This time they hung it in the library window, where everyone could see what it was.

Noah took his notebook from Mila and brushed a biscuit crumb off the cover.

“Can I finish the last page tonight?” she asked.

He nodded. “Bring it tomorrow. And the pencil.”

“I will.”

They bumped elbows because their hands were sticky.

Then Mila went home with Dad, leaving the paper moon shining in the window behind them.

CHAPTER 12

The Last Page

At home, Mila took off her shoes and found a tiny dry leaf stuck to one sock.

She set it on the kitchen table beside Noah's notebook. It was shaped a little like the damaged trolley wheel, if the wheel had been green and had a stem.

Dad put the kettle on.

“Milk?” he asked.

Mila nodded. She was thirsty in a sleepy sort of way. Her legs felt as if they were still walking.

She opened the notebook to Noah's sums. Then came her first notes, his drawing of the yard, the wheel with a bite, and the box with its two messages.

At the bottom of that drawing was the word she had pressed so hard into the page.

Found.

She ran a finger lightly over the marks on the other side. She could feel them without turning the paper over.

Dad set a cup of milk beside her.

“How's the last page?”



“Empty so far.”

Mila reached for the pencil.

It wasn't beside the notebook. She checked beneath the leaf and under the book. She patted both pockets.

“Oh, no.”

“What?”

“I've lost Noah's pencil.”

Dad took a sip of tea. “When did you last have it?”

“At the library. No, here. I had it when we came in.”

She pushed back her chair. Perhaps it had rolled under the table.

Dad was smiling into his mug.

“What?” she asked.

He touched the side of his head, just above his ear.

Mila put her hand to her own head.

There was the pencil, tucked behind her ear like Mrs. Bell's.

“I knew that,” she said.

Dad raised his eyebrows.

“I knew it just now.”

They laughed, and Mila sat down again. She laid the pencil flat across the open notebook where she could see it.

“This one was a short case,” Dad said.



Mila drank some milk. Then she turned to a clean page.

She drew the moon hanging in the library window. Her circle wasn't as round as Noah would have made it. She added the crooked paper join, the little star patch, and the strings along the bottom.

Below it she wrote, *Mila and Noah found the moon.*

She looked at the sentence for a moment.

Then she added, *Bea helped. Dad helped. Mrs. Bell, June, and Mr. Moss helped too.*

“That's quite a page,” Dad said.

“There's still room.”

At the bottom, she drew the trolley. This time she remembered all four wheels, including the one partly hidden behind the others.

Dad rinsed their cups. Water splashed softly into the sink.

Mila didn't write anything more about Bea. She had said the important part to Bea herself.

She closed the notebook and put the pencil through its elastic loop. Tomorrow, she would return them together.

Upstairs, Mila washed the last stickiness from her fingers. Dad found a clean pair of pajamas while she brushed her teeth.

She could hear him moving around her room, putting a book beside the bed and drawing the curtains partway across.

“Leave a little gap,” she called through her toothpaste.

He did.

When she climbed into bed, a strip of moonlight lay across the blanket. She put her hand into it. The light didn't feel different from the rest of the room, but she liked having it there.

Dad sat beside her.

“A story?”

Mila looked at the book he held, then shook her head. “Tomorrow.”

He kissed the top of her head and switched off the lamp.

Through the curtain gap, the real moon shone above the rooftops. Their paper one was safe in the library window, with its small star showing.

Mila curled her hand beneath her cheek.

She knew where both moons were.

A little more to wonder about

You can talk about these together, or just close the book and keep your favorite part.

Which clue first helped you guess where the moon had gone?

What did Mila believe before she had enough proof?

How did Noah help in a way Mila could not have managed alone?

If you had a detective notebook, what would you put on the first page?

Try this: choose an ordinary object in the room. Describe three things you can see about it without saying its name. Can someone guess what it is?